Chapter 18: Fight to the Death. Don't Die.

Catria was not wearing her necklace as she entered the arena with her team and Erik. She didn't expect at all that a part grogosh, part pixie war mage robbed her. She'd looked for the necklace and guessed it had broken and likely fallen off in the woods somewhere.

Thus, she was shocked when York announced, "Our first battle will be Alfir against Remere, where Alfir is attacking for the return of stolen gems. Our second battle will be Freya Flashdaggers from Aschelle fighting Catria from Terrian for the return of her stolen dagger."

"I didn't steal anything!" Catria argued.

"Silence!" York demanded. "You are not team captain."

"She didn't steal anything!" Rhys defended.

York held up Catria's necklace and asked, "Is this yours, Catria?"

"It is," she answered honestly. "It went missing."

York glared at her. “The person who robbed Freya dropped this when she did. It is yours, so you are the robber.”

“No!” Rhys insisted. “Catria doesn’t steal. Think about this. She has unicorn.”

“It is enough evidence to challenge,” York declared. “The fight will happen.”

“But…” Rhys began.

“The decision is final,” York declared. “Any more argument and you will be punished.”

Rhys became instantly quiet. York was not bluffing.

“What do I do?” Catria panicked.

“You have to fight,” Rhys answered. “I wish you didn’t, but if you don’t, York will not just have you punished, he will have you killed for the crime.”

Catria began to sob. Hrod hugged her and stroked her hair, assuring her, “You can win.”

“But Freya is good and much more experienced,” Catria countered. “She fights dirty too.”

“True,” Hrod admitted, “but you have unicorn.”

Erik suddenly stepped over to Hrod. He’d come from Cruia’s platform. “I’ll take it from here.”

Hrod stepped back and let Erik hug Catria. “I’ll see if I can fight for you,” he consoled. “I will not let them hurt you.”

She said nothing, but hugged him tightly and cried.

The fight between Alfir and Ramere seemed very long and very fast at the same time. Alfir won, so Ramere was tasked with returning the stolen gems.

“We didn’t steal the gems,” Roy, Ramere’s captain, argued. We can’t return what we didn’t steal.”

York thought for a moment and decided “Then you will take punishment and return gems of equal value.”

Roy gasped, “But…”

“Argue and I have you put you death,” York threatened.

Roy didn’t argue. He went with the lesser war mages who came for him and took the punishment.

Catria hid her face in Erik’s shoulder as she heard Roy scream in pain. What if that happened to her?

“It’s just to gems dark,” sh assured herself.

“No,” Erik corrected. “Your fight is an accusation. Freya can kill.”

Catria gasped and hugged him tighter.

She was right to be worried. When York called for her fight verses Freya, he announced, “Since this is a fight of accusation, both sides may fight past gems going dark. Freya may concede.”

“What if I do?” Catria asked, tensing in anticipation of the answer.

“That is an admission of guilt,” York explained. “You will then be turned over to Aschelle to be punished for

your crimes." A suppressed smile crossed his face.

"I'm not guilty!" Catria insisted.

York held his hand up to quiet her amd calmly responded, "Prove it on the battle field."

"No!" Erik insisted. "In a fight to the death, let me fight in her place. I'm her betrothed. I should be allowed to."

"Carlin would have…"

"Enough!" York insisted. "You will take punishment for arguing."

"No!" Erik insisted. "It's not fair! I want to fight in her place. If you want to let Quex fight for Freya, that's fine. I'll…"

"Quiet!" York yelled. "Argue more, and I can have you more than punished."

Erik was angry enough that he almost did, but Catria stopped him, urging, "If I can't win this, save me, please."

"I will," he assured her. "My shields can keep her from killing you, and I have the range to protect you."

He gave her a kiss and she took the field.

Hrod walked up to him. "You know that if you help her, you will be killed, don't you."

"I know," Erik confirmed, "but better me than her. I love her. I can't let her die."

He walked down from the platform and stood at the

half wall the crowd looked down into the arena over wishing he could help.

Hrod came with him, also feeling helpless. Both stared at Catria on the field.

She stood tall with her staff ready. Freya stood across from her with her keyoketsu shoge, a weapon similar to Hrod's but where his had metal balls at the end of the chains, her had knives.

Freya laughed at Catria before the fight started and taunted, "Prepare to die!"

Catria said nothing back, but took a deep breath to fight her fear.

York then called, "The fight may begin now."

Freya immediately threw her chain around Catria's staff and almost pulled it from her hands, but Catria held on. She did lose her balance slightly, so she missed a block where Freya threw the blade around her and struck across her back.

Catria's shielding held, but she still felt the strike.

She came back with a hard advance against Freya and knocked her feet out from under her.

"You're dead!" Freya threatened as she stood up.

The fight became more intense, and everyone was on the edge of their seats.

"I'm going down there!" Erik insisted as Catria's shielding went down and Freya drew blood.

Hrod physically held him back, warning, “You will be punished or killed.”

“But I can’t let them kill her!” Eric panicked.

Catria landed a good hit on Freya, but her shielding held. Freya used the strike to wrap the chain around Catria’s staff, pull it, and cut her with a knife.

Catria screamed but pulled her staff loose and struck again.

Catria did start to heal as she fought, but slowly, so every strike Freya hit against her weakened her, and more blood ran down her clothing.

“I’m going!” Erik insisted, starting to jump over the wall, but Hrod pulled him back again, scolding, “They will kill you, and she can win this.”

Erik grabbed his arm. “What if she doesn’t?”

“Then shield her,” Hrod answered, “but only if you must.”

As he said that, Catria struck the blow that made Freya’s gem go dark, but Freya landed a knife in Catria’s chest.

Catria fell in a pool of blood. Freya came to strike the killing blow, but Catria let loose a blast of bright light that pushed Freya back twenty feet and made her hit the ground hard.

Erik jumped over the wall and to the field, quickly kneeling beside Catria. He put up an energy shield around both him and her and tried to stop the bleeding.

He expected Freya to try to get through the energy shield, but she didn't get up.

Erik didn't care if she was unconscious or dead. His entire focus was on Catria.

"Live," he begged.

She reached up and took his hand, but didn't open her eyes.

"I love you," Erik assured her. "You can heal from this." He then leaned over and kissed her.

The wound stopped bleeding, and everyone watched, a terrified but amazed silence filled the arena.

After a few minutes, Catria muttered, "I love you."

Most of the crowd cheered, but the team from Aschelle glared down at her.

They did help revive Freya. As soon as she became conscious, she complained, "Catria cheated, so did Erik."

"Catria didn't cheat!" Erik defended. "You were already unconscious when I came down."

There was an argument, but York called everyone to be quiet. "Catria knocked Freya out and won honestly," he decreed.

Erik sighed in relief until York added, "But Erik didn't know Freya was unconscious when he came down, so his intent was to interfere. He will be punished. Thirty lashes by a lesser war mage."

"But I…" Erik began.

“Silence!” York demanded. “If you argue, the punishment will be doubled.”

Erik didn’t argue.

“I’ll heal you,” Catria mumbled.

“Heal yourself,” Erik responded. “I’ll be fine. My shielding is still up.”

His confidence shook as York announced, “Before the punishment, any war mage may challenge Erik to take his shielding down. He will keep fighting until his gem goes dark.”

Quex jumped up, urging, “I’m first!”